

URA MUSHROOM CONSERVATION AND MARKETING GROUP

Mushroom Foraging Activity

1. Background

Ura Mushroom Conservation and Marketing Group (UMCMG) under Ura gewog, Bumthang was initially established in 2013 and revised management plan in the year 2022. The management plan was developed as per the Framework for Management and Marketing of Non-Wood Forest Products. The plan was approved by Secretary, MoAF with recommendation for Director, Department of Forests and Park Services. However, UMCMG plan which was approved in the year 2022 do not cover the mushroom foraging activity. On 18th July 2023, consultation meeting was held in Ura gewog hall among the UMCMG committee members and other stakeholders. The committee members of UMCMG decided to initiate mushroom foraging activity as tourism product.

2. Objective

The main objective of initiating this activity is to generate income through diversification of nature-based tourism.

3. Regulations and norms

Representatives from mushroom sub-group and GT members of Ura gewog met on 1st August 2023 and developed regulations and norms for implementation of mushroom foraging activity. All the members of UMCMG shall adopt the following regulations and norms;

3.1. Arrangement for a mushroom forager (tourists)

- a. The tour operators shall contact any committee members of the sub-group or directly to the nominated local guide for the mushroom forage programming.
- b. The tourists/guests shall be accompanied by a local guide while entering the mushroom growing areas.
- c. The mushroom foraging program shall be provided in two categories with payment of minimal fees by the mushroom foraging group. The All the sub-group members shall follow the following fee collection norms.

<i>Category</i>	<i>Duration</i>	<i>No. of mushroom forager in a group</i>	<i>Fees per head (Nu.)</i>
I	<i>Up to 3 hours</i>	5 and below	500.00
		6 and above	300.00
II	<i>3-8 hours</i>	5 and below	1000.00
		6 and above	600.00

- d. All the collected fees shall be deposited in the sub-group account.

- e. Local guide shall be paid with Nu.1000/- for Category-I and Nu.1500/- for Category-II and must be borne by the mushroom foraging group.
- f. The foragers (a group) can collect mushrooms at a maximum of 1 kg. However, the foragers can take more than 1 kg with payment of price at prevailing local market rate.

3.2. A. Responsibility of committee members of UCMG and local guides

- a. The safety of the tourists/guest shall be the responsibility of the group members.
- b. It shall be the responsibility of the group members if any casualty or mushroom poisoning is foreseen during the implementation of the activity and shall provide full assistance and support to the affected tourists or guests.
- c. The fee collection system shall be applicable to mushroom foraging activity only. It shall not be applicable to any other tourism activities such as bird watching, walk through eco-trail or hiking trail etc.
- d. Brief foragers on mushroom management and harvesting techniques prescribed in the management plan.
- e. Encourage foragers to carry a basket for collecting mushrooms (no plastic bags).
- f. The local guide shall be fully responsible to lead the tourist in the growing area.
- g. All the required equipment/tools for mushroom foraging shall be arranged by the committee or local guide.
- h. All the information shall be shared with the chairman/committee.
- i. The collected fees by the local guide shall be handed over to the committee and shall be deposited in group account within 15 days.
- j. Group Saving Account will be opened and maintained in any financial institution by sub-group. The Secretary and Treasurer will make all deposits and countersign in all withdrawal.
- k. The committee members of sub-group may appoint one or two local guide and share their contact number to tour operators.

B. Responsibility of Park Office

- i. Monitor the implementation of the group's plan and verify the records maintained by management committee members.
- ii. The Ura Range Office shall conduct regular patrolling and monitoring of the mushroom growing area.

C. Power of the Department

- i. The Department of Forests and Park Services shall inspect, monitor, review the records and reports submitted by the respective field offices. Accordingly, the Department shall instruct the field office and group on the need for rectification and corrections of works/activities, if any.
- ii. The Department of Forests and Park Services has the right to cancel, reinstate or terminate the group and its plan in case of any violation of the management plan prescription as per FNCA and FNCRR 2023.

4. Fine and penalties

Any activity carried out without permission from committee members, beyond approved management (UMCMG's plan, 2022) and these norms shall be treated as an offense, and shall impose penalties as follows:

Sl. No	Offences	Penalties
1	Tourist guide failing to inform the members and guiding the tourists inside the mushroom growing area	A tourist guide shall be liable to pay a sum of Nu. 2000/- per occasion
2	Local guide not informing to committee on the visit of mushroom growing area by tourists/guest	Nu. 1500/-
3	Not depositing collected fee to group account by Local Guide (within 15 days)	Nu.20/- per day
4	Charging extra price for tourist (more than prevailing local market rate)	70% of the payment received must deposit to group account.
5	<i>Other offences case shall be dealt as per the plan and by-laws of UMCMG (part 2.15, page 16).</i>	

5. Details of Management committee members

Sl. No	Village	Name	Responsibility	Contact no.
1	Shingkhar	Pema Tshering	Member	77622148
2	Somthrang	Tenzinla	Chairman	17863787
3	Pangkhar	UgyenLhamo	Member	17412753
4	Beteng	Pema Yoedchang	Member	17805481
5	Ura-Doshi	Pema Norbu	Member	77663105
6	Shingnyer	Tsheltrim	Member	16913396



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ROYAL GOVERNMENT OF BHUTAN
MINISTRY OF ENERGY & NATURAL RESOURCES
DEPARTMENT OF FORESTS & PARK SERVICES
FOREST RESOURCES PLANNING AND MANAGEMENT DIVISION



DoFPS/FRPMD/NWFP-01/2023/ 457

21/11/2023

Notesheet

Subject: Approval for inclusion of mushroom foraging activity in UMCMP

The Forest Resource Planning and Management Division had received proposal on inclusion of mushroom foraging activity in the Ura Mushroom Conservation and Marketing Plan (UMCMP) which was revised and approved in the year 2022 for a period of 5 years (2022-2027). The idea of mushroom foraging activity as a tourism product was proposed by the members of the group and shall benefit the group members in generating income to uplift the livelihood and economy of the rural people.

The proposal was reviewed by Phrumsengla National Park and submitted to this Division for further review. Accordingly, the proposal was reviewed jointly by Nature Conservation Division and Forest Resource Planning and Management Division.

Therefore, in accordance with Section 142 of the Forest and Nature Conservation Act of Bhutan 2023, this Division Office would like to recommend for inclusion of mushroom foraging activity for Ura Mushroom Conservation and Marketing Group based on the recommendation from Phrumsengla National Park. However, the validity of plan shall remain until 2027.

Submitted by:



(Sonam Tobgay)
Chief Forestry Officer

Approved by:



(Lobzang Dorji)
Director